

because there is no causal link, correlation works just as well in either direction. Why not, then, I decided, use stock market action to predict the winner of the Super Bowl? That way, we could win big bucks in one day, and not have to wait eleven months for the poky old stock market to follow the Super Bowl Indicator.

The Acorn Super Bowl Secret (ASS) is the converse of Stovall's Super Bowl Indicator:

1. If the first five days of January show a gain for the S&P 500, the "original" NFC team will win.
2. If the first five days of January show a loss for the S&P 500, the AFC team will win.

Looking at the twenty-one Super Bowls through 1987, when I undertook my study, the ASS rule predicted the winners with 90 percent accuracy. We had the secret of instant wealth!

So what happened in 1988? The first five days of January were down, so ASS predicted a Denver victory. Instead, Denver got scalped, and our statistician was left looking like a Bronco's ASS.

In the eight years since, though, the indicator has worked remarkably well: the bettor who relied on it would have had six wins, one loss (1994), and one no bet (since the market was flat the first days of 1990). But it could just as easily have gone the other way. I'm afraid the secret of instant wealth remains elusive. The moral for stock market technicians? Statistical correlation without any reasonable causal link between variables is worthless.